

SOCIETY'S REPORT FOR 2001–2004

by R. Bellinger, F.I.A.

Hon. General Secretary

Membership

At the Annual General Meeting in 2000 it was agreed to raise subscriptions from 1 January 2001. This resulted in a serious loss of members in the following year, representing about 15% of the total membership, far worse than on previous occasions when subscription levels had been increased. Small losses continued in subsequent years and at the end of the four years numbers stood at 518, down by 89 on 1 January 2001. The reduced membership was one of the reasons why the Society's Council set up a working party to examine the future of the Society.

Winter lectures

The 2001/2 season was the last to be held at the Assembly House, Norwich, and in October of 2002 the Society moved to the Town Close Auditorium at Norwich Castle. As usual the Society joined with each of the *Norfolk Archaeological and Historical Research Group* and the *Prehistoric Society* for one of its lecture meetings, and in addition presented as part of its programme the *Sue Margeson Memorial Lecture*.

Whilst the majority of lectures dealt with archaeological and historical subjects which concerned Norfolk or East Anglia, at least one lecture each year covered events in the wider world, such as 'Making a Future for Archaeology in Albania', presented by Professor Richard Hodges in November 2002, and 'Recent Discoveries in Japanese Archaeology' by Dr Simon Kaner in the 2004/5 series.

The average attendance at the lectures during the four years was 80.

An additional 'prestige' lecture was held in September 2004 at the John Innes Centre in Norwich, when Carenza Lewis of Channel 4's *Time Team* programme talked to an audience of 130. The evening was highly enjoyable, but made a financial loss. This was mainly due to a failure of the advance publicity. Nevertheless this was felt to be a valuable experience for the future.

Excursions

In 2003 Margaret Forrester took over from Christopher Barringer in arranging summer excursions, but the format remained more or less the same, with walks, visits to country houses, churches, prehistoric and historic monuments and occasional trips by coach to more distant venues.

Villages and towns in Norfolk to receive our attention included Great Melton, Diss, Hingham, Cringleford, Old Costessey and King's Lynn; joint visits with the *Norfolk Archaeological Trust* involved a riverboat visit to St. Benet's Abbey, South Creake and Warham Iron Age Hillforts and Binham Priory; Annual General Meetings were held successively at Downham Market, Thetford, Cromer and Norwich.

The July 2002 AGM was incorporated into a day commemorating the 250th anniversary of the death of Francis Blomefield.

Brian Ayers continued to lead coach tours in September of each year, visiting North Wales in 2001, Flanders in 2002, Durham in 2003 and Bath in 2004. The Flanders trip was only the second

visit abroad by the Society and included six nights in Bruges. Visits included Ypres, Lisseweg, Antwerp and Ename. Twenty-seven members took part.

Publications

In each year a Part of the Society's journal, *Norfolk Archaeology*, was edited by Alan Davison and Trevor Ashwin and newsletters were produced by Rosemary O'Donoghue each spring and autumn.

Garsett House and the Library

The Library continued to operate from Garsett House, in the middle of Norwich, this building having been our headquarters since 1951. However in an historic decision in October 2004, it was decided that the building should be sold and the library transferred to a new venue.

The Norfolk Archaeological Trust had been responsible for the running of the building since 1998 but in 2004 they decided they no longer could undertake this task and asked the Society to take the building back. The Society had passed the building to the Trust because the trustees felt uncomfortable with their role and responsibilities, partly due to the increased requirements laid upon trustees by the *Charities Commission* and partly due to the risks associated with an unincorporated association in a climate of increasing litigation. A small group of trustees running the building again was not considered acceptable and therefore the sale of Garsett House became inevitable. At the end of 2004 the building was put up for sale, and it was sold in the spring of 2005.

Our Librarian, Barbara Green, assisted by Rosemary O'Donoghue completed cataloguing the Society's photograph and postcard collection and dealt with books and papers left to the Society by the late Edwin Granger.

Following the decision to sell Garsett House, Barbara, Rosemary and Paul Rutledge have spent much time preparing for the storing of the library collection, prior to being established in a new home.

General

A working party was set up in October 2002 to examine the future of the Society. It was also asked to look at the future of Garsett House (see above). The working party reported back to Council over the next 18 months, covering every aspect of the Society's activities and making a number of important recommendations. Many of these were accepted by Council and will be put into effect over the next few years.

In July 2004 Council asked for a questionnaire to be issued to members of the Society to ascertain views upon all the activities undertaken. Nearly 50% of members responded and the extremely helpful results were set out in the Spring 2005 Newsletter. As well as confirming the value of the library to members, the importance of the newsletters and *Norfolk Archaeology*, a number of offers of help were put forward which will make running the Society easier in the future.

The Society considers that it has an important role in commenting upon and making representations on archaeological and historical issues of local and national importance. During the period of this review several major national issues have been raised, including the quite unreasonable practice of charging VAT on repairs to listed buildings. This makes it more profitable to demolish an old building and rebuild than to make repairs. Subsequently in the 2001 budget the

Chancellor did announce that there would be reduced VAT of 5% on church repairs, but no wider concession was made.

A submission was made to the *All-Party Parliamentary Archaeology Group* on the current state of archaeology in the United Kingdom, setting out a number of issues felt to be of importance. As well as national issues, various local issues arose, one of which involved a major crisis in the funding of the County's museums. St. Peter Hungate Museum was closed, but threats to the Bridewell Museum and Strangers Hall were averted.

Thanks to the efforts of one of our members, Rosemary Bowden-Smith, we have received three grants in three years, totalling £4000, from the *Moncrieff Charitable Trust*. These have been used to archive the Society's photograph collection and to extend the size of *Norfolk Archaeology*, beyond that justified by subscription income.

In 2003 Judy Sims, who had organised the local branch of the *Young Archaeologists Club* for the past 15 years, decided that she should pass the responsibility to someone else. We were pleased to hear that Sophie Cabot has now taken on the task, and she is running the club from a room provided by Norwich Cathedral.

The Society made a donation of £250 in April 2004 to help save the archive of the glass firm, G. King and Son.

The Society set up a web site in mid-2004. Its address is www.nnas.info.

Accounts

The main features from the Society's accounts over the quadrennium are as follows. (NB. New accounting rules were applied in 2004, making comparisons between 2003 and 2004 difficult.)

Year to 31 December	2001 £	2002 £	2003 £	2004 £
<i>Income</i>				
Subscriptions	6916	6596	7343	7268
Interest	833	526	454	625
Tax relief from Covenants/Gift Aid	-	763	686	616
Net income from Society's Activities	(384)	(406)	9	646
Grants from <i>Moncrieff Charitable Trust</i>	-	1500	1500	1000
Other income	375	384	524	1065
Total	7740	9363	10 516	9928
<i>Expenditure</i>				
<i>Norfolk Archaeology</i> printing, less grants	4210	5138	4070	4155
Library	1757	1919	1160	1683
Web site	-	-	-	468
Other expenditure	2481	2250	1906	2264
Total	8448	9307	7136	8570
End of year credit balance	£21 164	£21 220	£24 600	£22 390